

Bangladesh



Bangladesh lies at the north end of the Bay of Bengal and frequently suffers devastating flood, cyclones, and famine. It seceded from Pakistan in 1971.



GEOGRAPHY

Mostly flat alluvial plains and deltas of the Brahmaputra and Ganges rivers. Southeast coasts are fringed with mangrove forests.



CLIMATE

Hot and humid. During the monsoon, water levels can rise 20 ft (6 m) above sea level.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

After a period of military rule, Bangladesh returned to democracy in 1991; political instability has continued, however, and corruption is a major problem. Half of the population live in poverty, but living standards are improving. Women are prominent in politics, but their rights are neglected.



INSIGHT: *Torrential monsoon rains flood two-thirds of the country every year*



THE ECONOMY

Agriculture is vulnerable to unpredictable climate. Bangladesh accounts for 90% of world jute fiber exports. Poor infrastructure deters investment. Growing textile industry.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: People's Republic of Bangladesh

DATE OF FORMATION: 1971

CAPITAL: Dhaka

POPULATION: 162 million

TOTAL AREA: 55,598 sq. miles
(144,000 sq. km)

DENSITY: 3138 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Bengali*, Urdu, Chakma, Marma, Garo, Khasi, Santhali, Tripuri, Mro

RELIGIONS: Muslim (mainly Sunni) 87%, Hindu 12%, other 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Bengali 98%, other 2%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Taka = 100 poisha